Project 2 Checkpoint: Writeup

1. Propositions

Trajectory (Decoupling vs. Crisis):
Side A (Progress): Global economic growth is successfully decoupling from carbon emissions through long-term industrial efficiency gains.
Side B (Crisis): Global climate mitigation has stalled as absolute emissions continue to surge to dangerous historic highs.
Accountability (Legacy Sectors vs. Large Nations):
Side A (Structural Shift): Modern high-value economies are intrinsically low-carbon; residual emissions are confined to a few legacy infrastructure sectors.
Side B (Sovereign Burden): A small number of large nations dominate absolute emissions, offsetting all other countries' mitigation efforts.

2. Personal Stance

Leaning: **Side B**.
Rationale: Physical climate risk is governed strictly by the cumulative mass of atmospheric emissions rather than economic efficiency ratios.

3. Deceptive & Rhetorical Techniques Used

Plot 1 (Side A - Carbon Intensity):
Selective Normalization: Plotted emissions per GDP unit instead of absolute emissions to show ~80% efficiency gains while concealing rising total emissions.
Extended Baseline: Used a 24-year timeframe (1995–2018) to create a smooth downward slope, masking short-term stagnation.
Plot 2 (Side B - Absolute Emissions Surge):
Temporal Cherry-Picking: Isolated 2004–2018 to frame post-recession growth as a structural runaway crisis.
Alarmist Headline Framing: Employed emotionally charged rhetoric ("Surging to Dangerous Highs") to induce crisis urgency without contextual baselines.
Plot 3 (Side A - Sector Intensities):
Axis Compression via Outlier: Retained extreme outlier sectors (electricity/marine transport), compressing the X-axis and flattening carbon-heavy manufacturing and mining bars to appear near-zero.
Plot 4 (Side B - National Tonnages):
Omission of Per-Capita Scaling: Visualized raw sovereign tonnages without population adjustment, singling out a handful of large nations while obscuring per-capita differences and historical cumulative emissions.